

Dipsas indica

Snail-eating snake



Length 23½–32 in (60–80 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Arboreal
Status Not evaluated

Location N. South America



A specialized feeder, this snake has jaws that are adapted for extracting snails from their shells—it forces its lower jaw into the shell, hooks its teeth into the flesh, and pulls it out. It hunts at night, resting in tree hollows during the day. The snail-eating snake has a slender body, with a distinctive ridge running along its back, and a rounded head with a blunt snout and large eyes. Males tend to be smaller and have proportionately longer tails.



Dispholidus typus

Boomslang

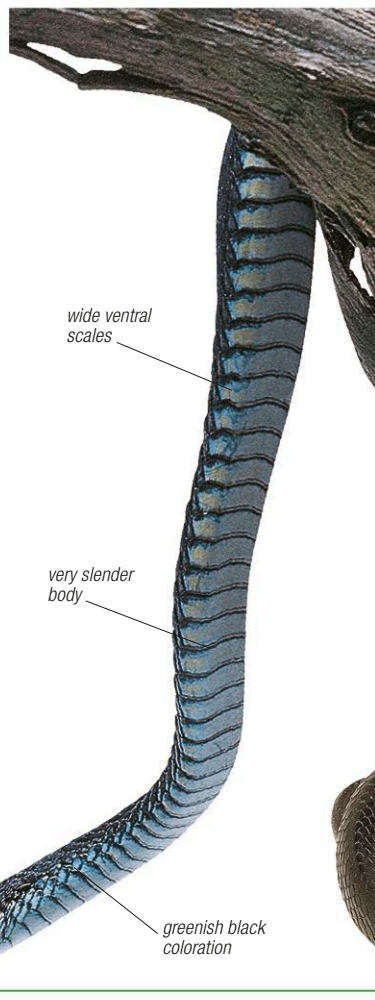


Length 3¼–5½ ft (1–1.7 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Arboreal
Status Not evaluated

Location Africa (south of Sahara)



Deriving its name from the Dutch word for tree (“boom”), this is one of Africa’s most venomous arboreal snakes. A highly agile climber, it uses its binocular vision to judge distances as it slips from one branch to another, and when it prepares to strike. Boomslangs feed on lizards, especially chameleons, and also on birds. Their fangs are at the back of their mouths, and they inject their venom by chewing their prey. Adult boomslangs are highly variable in color: they may be green, brown, or almost black, with or without contrasting markings. Males are more colorful than females. When threatened, usually by birds of prey and carnivorous mammals, they inflate their necks to appear larger, and will bite readily. Females lay clutches of up to 14 eggs in tree hollows and dead vegetation.



Drymarchon couperi

Eastern indigo snake

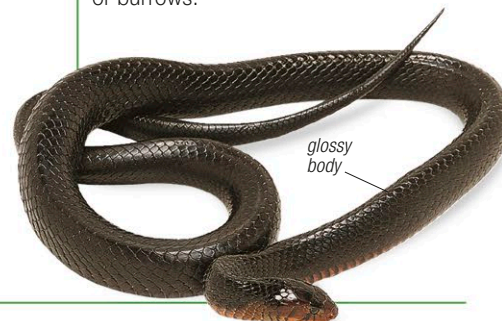


Length 7–9½ ft (2.1–2.9 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location S.E. USA



The eastern indigo snake is a glossy, black species found in the southeastern United States. It feeds on most animal groups—fishes, amphibians, lizards, other snakes, birds and their eggs, and small mammals. An opportunistic feeder, it can lunge very quickly at its prey, and sometimes presses it against the side of a burrow or a solid object. Females lay 4–12 eggs in tree stumps, vegetation, or burrows.



Pantherophis guttatus

Corn snake



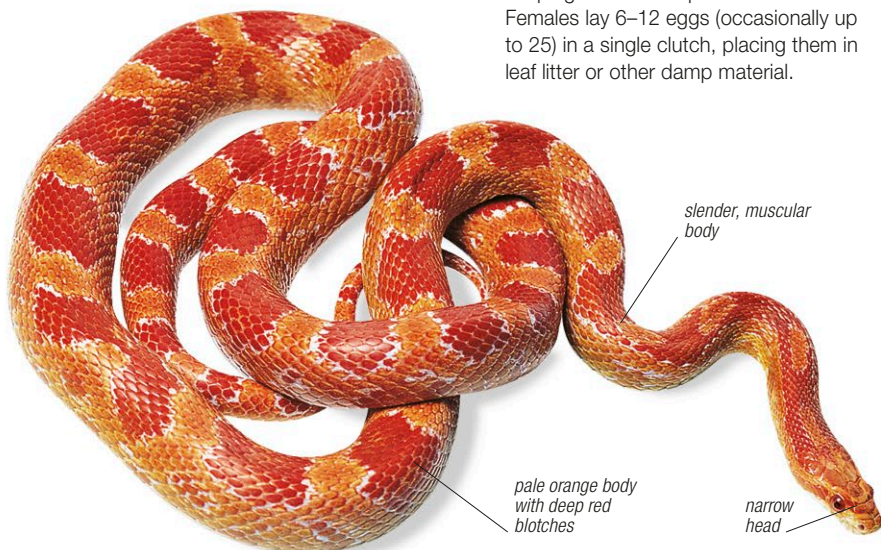
Length 3¼–6 ft (1–1.8 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Mainly terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location C. and S.E. USA



The corn snake is one of the most eye-catching of North America’s ratsnakes, a group that includes the gray ratsnake (see right) and the Trans-Pecos ratsnake (see opposite). Unlike most of its relatives, the corn

snake is extremely variable, with many region variants, some of which used to be regarded as separate subspecies. In addition, captive-bred corn snakes include forms that do not occur in the wild, such as the amelanistic one below, which lacks the black pigment, melanin. Mutants such as this can be selectively bred and crossed, giving rise to an almost infinite number of color and pattern morphs. Corn snakes are primarily nocturnal. They may be found on the ground, but often climb into trees and the roof timbers of houses and barns in search of food. To aid in climbing, their flanks meet their undersides at a sharp angle, which they use to grip bark and other rough surfaces. They feed mainly on small rodents, and are useful in keeping numbers of pests under control. Females lay 6–12 eggs (occasionally up to 25) in a single clutch, placing them in leaf litter or other damp material.



Pantherophis spiloides

Gray ratsnake

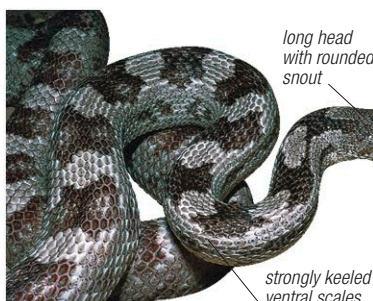


Length 4–6 ft (1.2–1.8 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location S. Canada, C. and E. USA



The gray ratsnake has more subdued colors than many related species, which may be yellow or orange. Gray ratsnakes favor rocky hillsides with open woodland, often near water, and are excellent swimmers. They feed on rodents and birds, which they kill by constriction. Females lay 5–20 eggs, occasionally up to 40, sometimes in communal sites. A ridge along the flanks helps the snake to wedge itself into the bark when climbing trees.



Zamenis longissimus

Aesculapian snake



Length 3¼–7¼ ft (1–2.2 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location S. Europe to W. Asia



The name of this snake derives from Aesculapius, the Greek god of medicine. It is thought to be the snake that, coiled around a staff, forms his motif, the caduceus, still used as a symbol of the medical profession today. The Aesculapian snake is olive or brown, occasionally dark gray, with a lighter patch on each side behind the head. The scales are smooth or slightly keeled, giving it a shiny appearance. An agile swimmer and climber, this secretive snake inhabits scrubland, forest edges, and fields, and hibernates during the cooler months.